WEEK 1: MINDSET / DAY 3 LEARNING / DAY 4 ACTIVITY

Being Assertive

Instructor Guide
Ranger Mastery Program

DAY 4: RANGER MINDSET REFLECTION

Assertiveness roundtable segment
30-minute live conversation for six technically skilled engineers.
Day 3 learning: *Becoming Assertive: Advocate for Your Interests*, TJ Guttormsen, LinkedIn Learning.

Where this fits

Participants complete the full Day 3 course independently, then discuss it together within Day 4's Ranger Mindset Reflection. Connect assertiveness with ownership, clear expectations, and composure. This is a standalone instructor guide for the assertiveness segment, not the complete Day 4 task brief.

The full course, not just its opening lesson

Introduction: what authentic assertiveness means.
Chapter 1 - Fundamental Concepts of Assertiveness: delivery, clarity, information, independent views, authority, and groups.
Chapter 2 - Assertive Habits and Traits: questions, opinions, requests, support, saying no, decisions, boundaries, and proactive communication.
Conclusion: discussing what helps these ideas transfer to real life.

OPENING / HEAR ALL SIX VOICES

Invite expression.
Make room for difference.

Use one starting question from each of the four discussion groupings, with selected follow-ups. Keep the whole conversation within 30 minutes; this is a bank of possibilities, not a checklist.

COURSE LESSONS COVERED

A few words about the course

SAY THIS AT THE START

We have all completed the assertiveness course. Today is a conversation, not a demonstration of confidence. I would like us to hear from everyone. Let's start with one brief reaction each: what resonated, or what did you find yourself questioning? You can use a work example, a hypothetical situation, or build on someone else's point.

Make participation safe and purposeful

Ask permission to invite people by name so the same voices do not always lead. Allow thinking time. A pass is acceptable; offer to return later with a specific, non-personal question. Do not judge confidence, eye contact, posture, accent, or how much someone speaks. Avoid identifying customers or colleagues.

Move beyond six isolated answers

Get an example: 'Can you take us to an occasion when that happened?'
Connect: 'Who recognizes that experience in a different situation?'
Contrast: 'Who sees it differently, and what changed the outcome?'
Make meaning: 'What does that tell us about the conditions that help people speak up?'

Invite quieter voices and limit domination

'Let's hear a perspective we haven't heard yet.' Or: 'Alex, how does that compare with what you have seen?' If someone dominates: 'I am going to pause us so another person can build on that.' If an answer is brief: 'What made the difference?' Do not hold another six-person round after every prompt.

Connect to the Ranger mindset without testing it

Where do ownership and respectful challenge reinforce each other? When does taking responsibility become agreeing to more than you can deliver? Invite stories rather than evaluating anyone's handling of a customer situation.

Instructor guardrail: assertiveness is not a personality contest, an instruction to dominate, or a guarantee that a powerful person will respond well. Respect cultural differences, accessibility needs, and real power imbalances.

CHAPTER 1 / FUNDAMENTAL CONCEPTS OF ASSERTIVENESS / DISCUSSION A

Be clear without overpowering.

Explore how people express a position and make requests understandable, without equating assertiveness with loudness or a single communication style.

COURSE LESSONS COVERED

Speech, eye contact, and body language
Being succinct and getting to the point
Assertive information and invitations

START WITH EXPERIENCE

Think of a conversation where your message was clearer, or less clear, than you intended. What influenced how the other person understood it?

Speech and nonverbal communication

What has helped a message sound calm and firm rather than hesitant or forceful? When have tone or pace changed how you interpreted the same words? How do those cues change in remote meetings or written messages?

Succinct is not the same as abrupt

When has too much explanation hidden the point you wanted to make? When has being brief left out context the other person needed? What helps you recognize the difference between a clear statement and a blunt dismissal?

Information and invitations

When have you thought you made a clear request, but the response showed otherwise? What was missing: purpose, context, the actual request, or an expectation? How can we invite a response without making agreement feel compulsory?

Respectful does not have to mean uncertain

What language helps you show respect without hiding your position? When has a qualifier been useful, and when has it weakened what you meant? How do we remain honest about uncertainty while being clear about what we do know?

CONNECT THE ROOM

Who achieves clarity in a different way? What seems to work across different styles, and what depends on context or the relationship?

Bridge: Clear expression is one part of the picture. What changes when the audience has more authority or several people are speaking?
Guardrail: do not require eye contact or a particular body posture as evidence of competence. Discuss the message's effect, not a person's identity.

CHAPTER 1 / FUNDAMENTAL CONCEPTS OF ASSERTIVENESS / DISCUSSION B

Speak up when the room is difficult.

Explore independent views, authority, and participation in groups. Keep the focus on respectful contribution, not on winning an argument.

COURSE LESSONS COVERED

Standing out from the crowd
Being assertive with authority figures
Being assertive in groups

START WITH EXPERIENCE

When have you had a relevant view but hesitated to share it? What made speaking up easier or harder?

A different view from the majority

What happens when a group seems to agree before you have had time to think? When has a dissenting view improved the discussion? What helps distinguish a constructive challenge from disagreement for its own sake?

Authority and power

How does the conversation change with a manager, senior colleague, or influential stakeholder? When have questions opened a useful conversation rather than created defensiveness? What made that possible, and what risks remained?

Finding space in a group

What makes it difficult to enter a fast-moving discussion? When have you seen someone make space for another person's contribution? What responsibilities do the people already speaking have toward quieter colleagues?

Respectful challenge under pressure

When have you needed to question an assumption while the other person wanted certainty? What helped you challenge the idea without attacking the person? What changes if the other person is not willing to listen?

CONNECT THE ROOM

Who has had a similar situation with a different outcome? What came from the speaker's approach, and what came from the culture, status, or behavior of the people listening?

Bridge: Speaking up is not only about difficult moments. What everyday habits help people express needs and contribute before pressure builds?
Guardrail: do not promise that respectful delivery removes risk. Do not ask anyone to disclose a sensitive conflict or challenge a leader in the room.

CHAPTER 2 / ASSERTIVE HABITS AND TRAITS / DISCUSSION A

Ask, contribute, and seek support.

Discuss listening and questions alongside expressing opinions, making requests, asking for help, and participating in decisions.

COURSE LESSONS COVERED

Ask questions to be present
Build the habit of sharing your opinions
Become comfortable asking for what you want
How to assertively get help and support
Become an assertive decision-maker

START WITH EXPERIENCE

When has an unspoken need or preference turned into a misunderstanding? What made it hard to say what you needed?

Questions that show presence

When has someone's question made you feel genuinely heard? What is different about a curious question and a question used to make a point? How does listening change the way we advocate for our own interests?

Sharing an opinion without making it a contest

When have you withheld an opinion because it did not seem important enough? What helps you offer a view while leaving room to be influenced? When have opposing opinions improved a relationship rather than damaged it?

Asking for what you want

What do we sometimes expect others to notice without being told? When has a clear request helped, even when the answer was not yes? What makes a request different from a demand?

Help and support

When have you waited longer than was useful before asking for help? What was the concern behind waiting? What made a help request easy for someone else to respond to?

Contributing to decisions

When do you genuinely have no preference, and when do you leave a choice to others despite having a view? What helps you offer a suggestion without needing your preference to win?

CONNECT THE ROOM

What is common across our experiences of asking, helping, and deciding? What could make it easier for people to express a view before an issue grows?

CHAPTER 2 / ASSERTIVE HABITS AND TRAITS / DISCUSSION B

Boundaries that preserve respect.

Explore saying no, avoiding unnecessary justification, maintaining boundaries, and communicating before a problem develops.

COURSE LESSONS COVERED

The importance of saying no
Your no doesn't owe an explanation
Setting and enforcing your boundaries
Proactive communication gets you better results

START WITH EXPERIENCE

When have you agreed to something you did not really have the capacity or willingness to do? What made saying no difficult?

The cost of an automatic yes

What concerns come up when you consider declining a request? When has saying yes caused difficulties for someone else later? What has helped you disagree with a request while preserving the relationship?

Explanation or over-explanation?

How did you react to the course's idea that a no does not always need an explanation? When is context useful, and when does justification invite unwanted negotiation? How do work responsibilities change what must still be communicated?

Needs and boundaries

What is the difference between asking someone to meet a need and explaining a boundary you will maintain? When has a clearly communicated boundary made a relationship easier? What happens when a boundary is repeatedly ignored?

Communicating before the problem

When has raising a concern early prevented tension later? What makes people wait until they are already frustrated? How can we make an expectation visible without sounding accusatory?

CONNECT THE ROOM

Where do our experiences of boundaries differ? What seems to help both clarity and respect, and what needs an agreement rather than an individual decision?

Guardrail: explore personal agency without treating the lesson as permission to abandon agreed responsibilities or safety obligations. Context, decision rights, and appropriate escalation still matter. No one needs to deliver a scripted refusal.

CONCLUSION / COLLECTIVE INSIGHT / INSTRUCTOR HANDOVER

What do our experiences tell us?

Connect stories and perspectives without assigning practice, scoring confidence, or collecting commitments.

COURSE LESSONS COVERED

Action steps to take to practice these skills in the real world

INVITE COLLECTIVE MEANING

Across the experiences we have heard, what helps someone express a view clearly while still respecting the other person? Where does context change the answer?

Questions that turn stories into shared understanding

What did someone else's experience help you see differently?
Which tension came up more than once: clarity versus politeness, confidence versus uncertainty, or ownership versus overcommitment?
Where did a different experience challenge something we were assuming?
What depends on individual habits, and what depends on the environment?
What question about assertiveness are we still leaving open?

Reflect the discussion, not a verdict

Say: 'I heard [shared pattern], but also [important difference]. Does that reflect the conversation?' Invite corrections, not forced consensus. Close within 30 minutes, without homework, action plans, or a compulsory closing round.

When the instructor needs to intervene

Silence: offer a hypothetical situation and invite reactions.
Unheard voices: 'Is there a perspective we have missed? Would you like to add one?'
Blame or disclosure: return to an anonymized pattern, not a judgment of someone.
Technical tangent: return to clarity, expectations, decisions, or boundaries.

Handover to a replacement instructor

Pass on remaining time, discussion groupings covered, the current question, and perspectives still to invite. Share themes, not sensitive details. Resume with a shaded prompt. No other instructor guide is needed to run this conversation.

SOURCE & SCOPE

TJ Guttormsen, *Becoming Assertive: Advocate for Your Interests*, LinkedIn Learning. All 17 lesson titles and syllabus descriptions checked October 24, 2026, covering the introduction, two chapters, and conclusion. Public authority-figures and decision-making transcripts also reviewed; full paid videos not watched. Prompts are original companion material, not an official LinkedIn instructor guide.

Full course and published syllabus / Ranger program materials and Day 4 activity